

DOSE OF PRAGG-MATISM
"It's great how chess's popularity has grown in the last six years"

SPORTS ▼

STRIKING A **BALANCE**

Fresh off one of the biggest wins of his chess career, R. Praggnanandhaa reflects on success, setbacks and learning to switch off

Grandmaster R. Praggnanandhaa is learning to loosen up. These days, he posts short recaps of his tournaments and shares light-hearted videos, like a viral one of making an omelette. The soon-to-be 21-year-old says he is "much more confident in front of the camera". This year, as world champion D. Gukesh has struggled with form, it is Praggnanandhaa and his older sister Vaishali Rameshbabu who made the right moves and won two top-tier tournaments in the Norway Chess and Candidates, respectively.

Praggnanandhaa, aka Pragg, does not mind the spotlight. "It is great how chess's popularity has grown in the last six years," he says. "Earlier, only major tournaments would be covered. Nowadays, Norway Chess gets so much coverage." The tournament saw Pragg wowing audiences as he beat five-time world champion Magnus Carlsen twice in the classical format. "Throughout, I was playing good quality games. I realised I have to work on time management, (the lack of) which led to mistakes and cost me games."

It's not just time management on board; players also have to manage a busy tournament calendar, which is packed with games across formats like freestyle and rapid and blitz. He credits his sponsor Adani for backing him—with training and travel—when the going got tough with a dip in form.

> Pragg beat **world champion Magnus Carlsen twice** in the classical format of the Norway Chess tournament

Pragg and his team have been more mindful balancing between play and rest and it has reflected in the results so far, including a tied first finish in rapid chess at the Grand Chess Tour in Croatia. Candidates 2026 didn't pan out the way he wanted—he finished seventh in a field of eight—but what helped him overcome the setback was seeing his sister, Vaishali, win the women's title. So, would he be helping her prep for the World Championship? "I'd be more helpful as a brother than as a chess player, like not do things that annoy her," he says with a smile. ■

—Suhani Singh